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Guest Experience Insights: Independent vs. Chain Boutique Hotels in Chicago

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Center for Hospitality & Retail Industries Business Analytics

Guest Experience Insights: Independent vs. Chain Boutique Hotels

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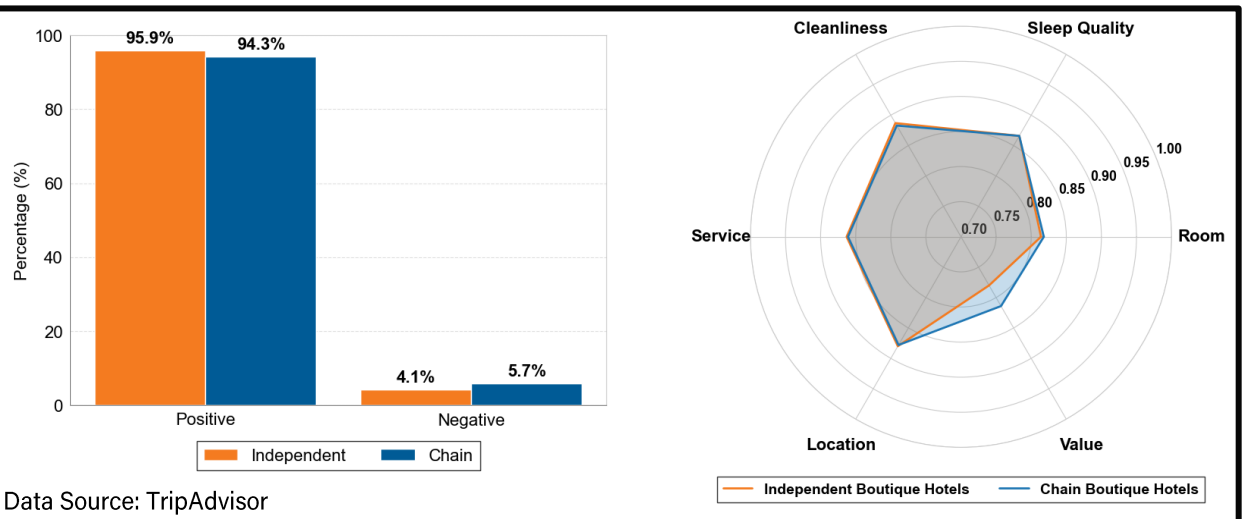
Research Overview

- **Chicago Boutique Hotel Review Analysis:** This study analyzes 15,875 TripAdvisor guest reviews from January 2015 to April 2025 for 11 independent and 25 chain boutique hotels in Chicago. Using advanced text analytics, guest feedback was categorized into six core experience areas: Room Quality, Sleep Quality, Cleanliness, Service, Location, and Value. This provides a decade-long view of sentiment trends.

- **Independent vs. Chain – Why It Matters:** This research is significant because independent boutique hotels are known for offering personalized, locally immersive experiences, contrasting with chain boutique hotels which typically blend unique design elements with the consistency and reliability of an established brand. By comparing these two distinct models, the study aims to identify which type is more effectively meeting the dynamic expectations of guests in an urban hospitality environment – is it the authentic character offered by independent properties or the dependable quality provided by chains?

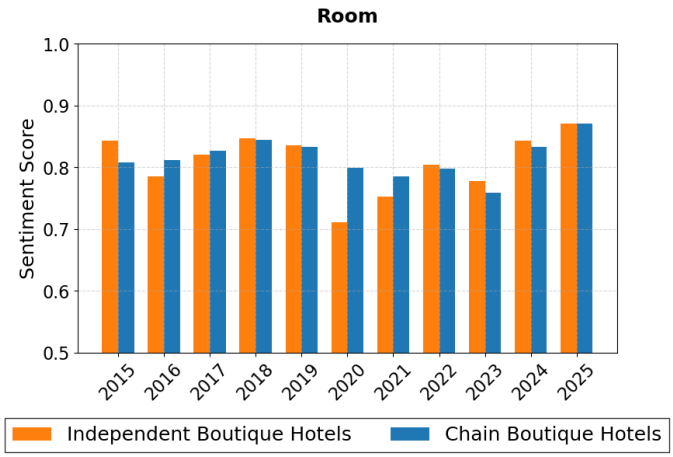
- **Key Findings:** Across both independent and chain boutique hotels, guest sentiment was notably strong concerning Cleanliness, Service, and Location 1 . However, the 'Value' dimension exhibited the most significant volatility, particularly observed during and immediately following the pandemic period 2 . Independent boutique hotels garnered more positive feedback related to personalized touches and the emotional connection they foster with guests 3 . In contrast, chain boutique hotels demonstrated more consistent guest satisfaction in areas such as sleep quality and cleanliness, likely a direct result of standardized operational procedures and rigorous quality control measures 4 .

Exhibit 1. Guest Sentiment Distribution Across Boutique Hotel Type



Data Source: TripAdvisor
Note) Bar chart presents sentiment distribution based on review scores. Radar chart shows average sentiment scores. Neutral sentiment was not observed in the dataset.

Exhibit 2. Trend in Guest Sentiment Score for Room and Sleep Quality

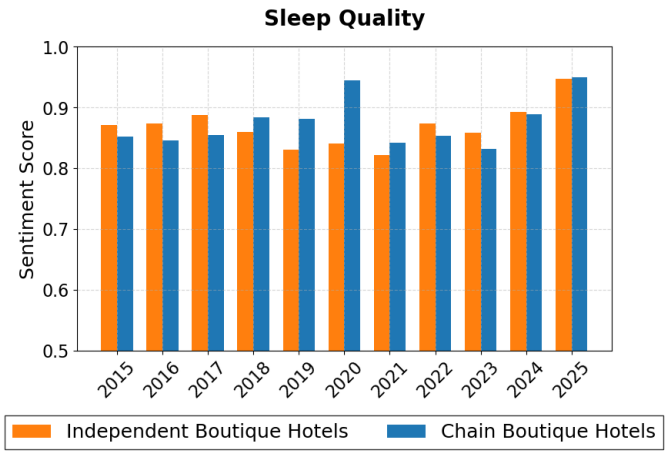


Hotel Type	Mean	SD
Independent Boutique Hotels	0.814	0.363
Chain Boutique Hotels	0.818	0.350

Note) Sentiment scores were calculated using a custom measure. Higher scores indicate more positive evaluations. *SD* = standard deviation, indicating variation across reviews.

CHRIBA Findings

- **Room Sentiment: Navigating Pandemic Impacts.** Room sentiment scores remained largely stable from January 2015 through April 2025, with notable dips during the pandemic years of 2020–2021. Independent Boutique Hotels achieved a strong post-pandemic recovery, reflecting efforts to enhance room ambiance and offer more personalized in-room experiences. Chain Boutique Hotels maintained slightly higher average scores, suggesting consistent standards in layout, cleanliness, and functional comfort. Overall, both hotel types successfully rebounded in room sentiment after the pandemic.



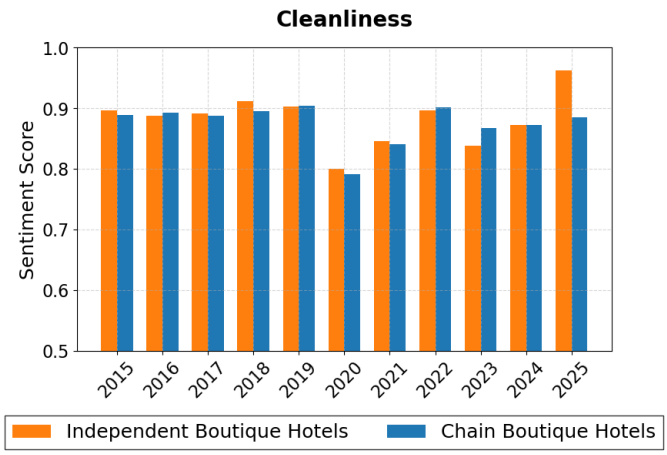
Hotel Type	Mean	SD
Independent Boutique Hotels	0.866	0.292
Chain Boutique Hotels	0.866	0.291

Note) Sentiment scores were calculated using a custom measure. Higher scores indicate more positive evaluations. *SD* = standard deviation, indicating variation across reviews.

CHRIBA Findings

- **Sleep Quality: Resilience and Consistency.** Sleep quality sentiment stayed high for both hotel types from 2015 to 2025, with a modest decline during the 2020–2021 pandemic. Independent Boutique Hotels rebounded strongly in the early post-pandemic period, though guest experiences varied—likely due to differences in room size, noise levels, and bedding comfort—highlighting the need to standardize core comfort elements across properties. Chain Boutique Hotels sustained steadier satisfaction through uniform layouts and dedicated sleep amenities.

Exhibit 3. Trend in Guest Sentiment Score for Cleanliness and Service

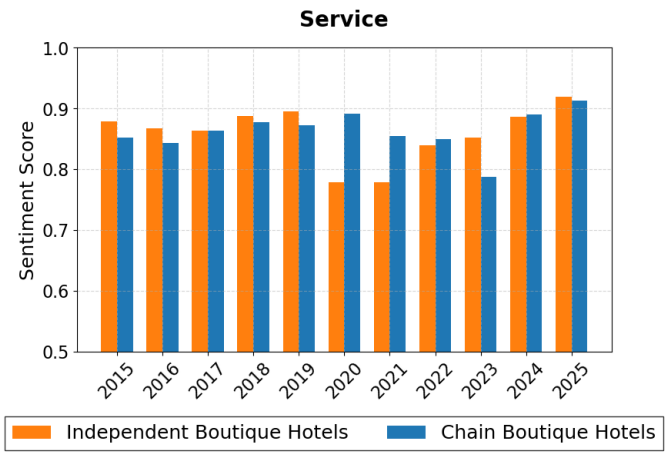


Hotel Type	Mean	SD
Independent Boutique Hotels	0.887	0.258
Chain Boutique Hotels	0.883	0.264

Note) Sentiment scores were calculated using a custom measure. Higher scores indicate more positive evaluations. *SD* = standard deviation, indicating variation across reviews.

CHRIBA Findings

- **Cleanliness: High Standards Maintained.** Cleanliness sentiment scores remained high across both hotel types from January 2015 to April 2025, with Independent Boutique Hotels slightly outperforming Chain Boutique Hotels in recent years. Although there was a modest dip during the pandemic, both quickly regained guest confidence. Chain Boutique Hotels displayed greater year-to-year stability, while Independent Boutique Hotels peaked in 2024—likely due to enhanced cleanliness protocols or property upkeep. This suggests that chains offer consistent standards, whereas independents can achieve peak guest satisfaction in this area.



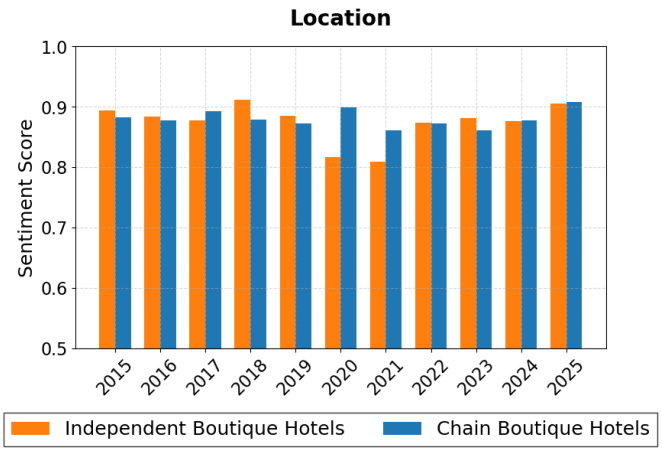
Hotel Type	Mean	SD
Independent Boutique Hotels	0.863	0.292
Chain Boutique Hotels	0.861	0.284

Note) Sentiment scores were calculated using a custom measure. Higher scores indicate more positive evaluations. *SD* = standard deviation, indicating variation across reviews.

CHRIBA Findings

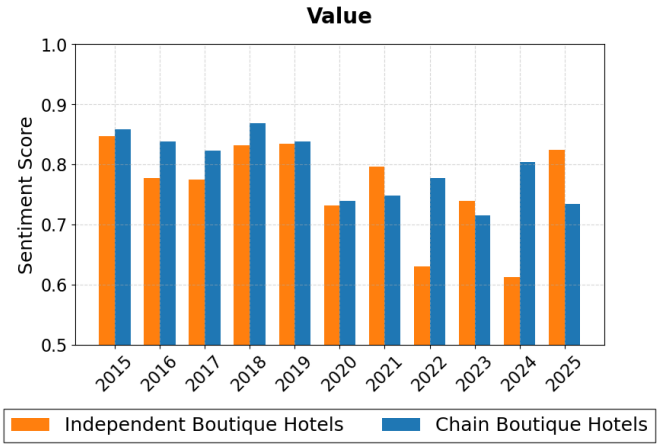
- **Service: The Rise of Personalized Experiences.** Service sentiment scores steadily improved after 2021, with Independent Boutique Hotels edging out Chain Boutique Hotels in average score. This suggests growing guest appreciation for personalized, emotionally engaging interactions as travelers sought more meaningful human contact during post-pandemic recovery. Both hotel types nevertheless maintained stable service sentiment over time, reflecting a consistent ability to meet expectations in hospitality and attentiveness. The trend highlights the increasing importance of personalized service in driving positive guest sentiment.

Exhibit 4. Trend in Guest Sentiment Score for Location and Value



Hotel Type	Mean	SD
Independent Boutique Hotels	0.880	0.242
Chain Boutique Hotels	0.878	0.240

Note) Sentiment scores were calculated using a custom measure. Higher scores indicate more positive evaluations. *SD* = standard deviation, indicating variation across reviews.



Hotel Type	Mean	SD
Independent Boutique Hotels	0.780	0.398
Chain Boutique Hotels	0.814	0.336

Note) Sentiment scores were calculated using a custom measure. Higher scores indicate more positive evaluations. *SD* = standard deviation, indicating variation across reviews.

CHRIBA Findings

- **Location: A Consistent Strength.** Location sentiment scores remained consistently high across both hotel types, with only minor declines during the pandemic years (2020–2021). Independent Boutique Hotels slightly outperformed Chain Boutique Hotels, possibly due to their presence in more distinctive or culturally rich Chicago neighborhoods. This suggests that the unique locations of independent hotels are a key differentiator. Chain Boutique Hotels exhibited more consistent sentiment trends, suggesting stable guest satisfaction with accessibility, transportation options, and urban convenience.

CHRIBA Findings

- **Value: The Most Volatile Factor.** Value sentiment scores showed the greatest fluctuation among all dimensions, particularly during and after the pandemic years. Independent Boutique Hotels had lower average scores overall, but experienced a notable rebound in recent years, indicating improved guest perceptions of value for money. Chain Boutique Hotels maintained a higher and more stable average, possibly due to standardized pricing models or bundled service offerings that reinforced predictability and perceived fairness. Understanding and managing guest perceptions of value is crucial for both hotel types, especially in response to market changes.

Data Description

- ❑ Data Source: TripAdvisor
- ❑ Review Data (written in English)
  - Data period: January 2015– April 2025
  - Descriptive information:

Variable	Independent Boutique Hotel	Chain Boutique Hotel
No. of Reviews	5,714	10,161
No. of Hotels	11	25

  - Topic Modeling with Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA)
    - 30 initial topics were identified and re-clustered into 6 refined topics.

❑ Independent Boutique Hotels

Theme	No. of Topics	Keywords
Aesthetic Design	11	decorated, elegant, charming, ambiance, theme, artistic, design, industrial, modern...
Room	7	clean, closet, bath, small, table, lighting, noise, mirror, dark, queen, sleep, upgrade, wall, bathroom, loud...
Amenities	1	rooftop, pool, gym, lounge, brunch, cafe, breakfast, snack, minibar, microwave, fridge, valet, parking, wifi...
Location	3	airport, metro, subway, downtown, accessible, central, directly, neighborhoods, attraction...
Employee Service	6	staff, friendly, helpful, service, warm, welcoming, bartender, team, guest, manager, housekeeping, accommodating...
Value	2	value, deal, price, worth, affordable, reasonable, discount, overpriced, reservation...

Data Description

❑ Chain Boutique Hotels

Theme	No. of Topics	Keywords
Aesthetic Design	15	lounge, décor, funky, aesthetic, elegance, style, themed, artistic, sleek, vintage, colorful, scene, urban, trendy...
Room	2	room, clean, small, bath, mirror, light, noise, temperature, wifi, addressed, seamless, comfort...
Amenities	5	breakfast, bar, spa, gym, club, lounge, refrigerator, microwave, cake, rooftop, view, terrace, parking, coffee...
Location	3	walking, downtown, uber, walk, near, spot, airport, transit, attraction, sightseeing, metro, taxi, shopping...
Employee Service	2	staff, helpful, friendly, attentive, excellent, accommodating, professional, responsive, welcoming, kind...
Value	3	value, budget, affordable, discount, deal, fair, cost, price, reasonable, worth, overpriced...

CHRIBA Findings

❑ Independent Boutique Hotels:

- Displayed stronger associations with **personalized service** and **emotionally expressive language** (e.g., *"friendly," "welcoming," "charming"*), reinforcing their strength in **ambiance** and **human connection**.
- This emotional appeal is further supported by **higher service sentiment scores**.
- However, frequent mentions of *"small," "noise,"* and *"dark"* under the *Room* theme—alongside greater variation in sentiment—suggest recurring concerns with **spatial comfort** and **lighting**. Addressing these issues may enhance the overall in-room experience.

❑ Chain Boutique Hotels:

- Emphasized **amenity-rich environments** and **visually consistent aesthetics** (e.g., *"funky," "vintage," "urban"*), reflecting strong **brand coherence**.
- Keywords such as *"seamless," "resolved,"* and *"professional"* in service reviews indicate **reliable operations**, a pattern also supported by **stable sentiment scores** in room and cleanliness.
- However, the **relative lack of emotionally rich expressions** highlights an opportunity to **enhance warmth and personal touch** in guest interactions.

ABOUT THE AUTHORS

Hwijin Baldick is a doctoral student in the White Lodging–J.W. Marriott School of Hospitality and Tourism Management at Purdue University, West Lafayette, Indiana, USA. Her research focuses on lodging, consumer behavior, and experience design, employing experimental design, computational text analysis, and AI-based agent modeling.

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